

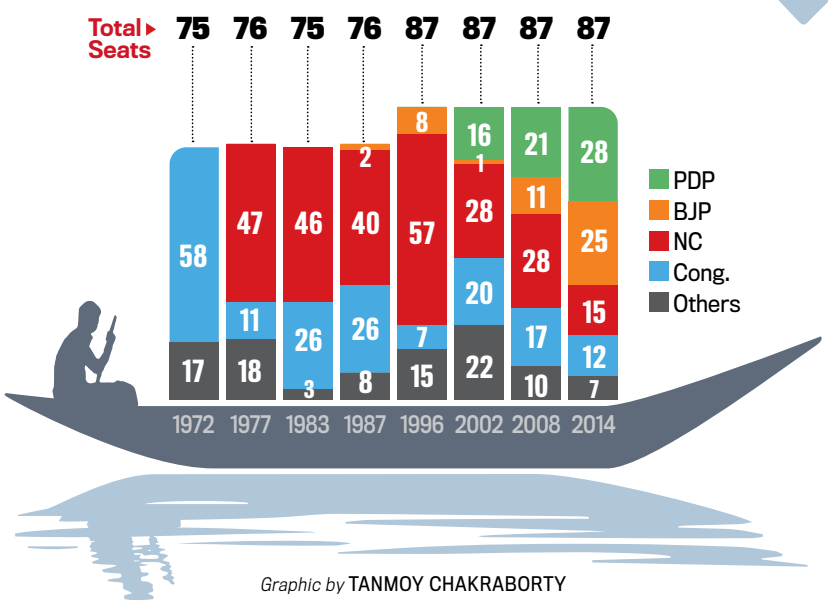
PODIUM OF PROGRESS
Prime Minister Narendra Modi joins state BJP leaders at a rally in Doda, Sept. 14

ANI

POLITICAL WATERS

The regional players and later the BJP have eaten into the Congress's political space in J&K over the past five decades

PARTY-WISE SEAT SHARE IN J&K ASSEMBLY ELECTIONS



Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

priving J&K of its exclusive special status, and simultaneously demoted it to a Union Territory, with Ladakh split off.

In another first, the incoming assembly will have a lifespan of five years instead of the six it used to have and will have 90 seats instead of the 87 earlier, despite Ladakh not being a part of it. It is also the first time in three decades that separatist forces have not called for a boycott of the election but are instead actively participating in it. Even the proscribed Jamaat-e-Islami Kashmir is putting up proxy candidates to fight on its behalf. Change had been evident in the turnout for the general election in May 2024, when J&K saw a record 58.4 per cent participation, a jump of 30 percentage points from 2019. The first phase of the assembly voting has already surpassed that, with a near-59 per cent turnout even in the terror-prone Valley zones, particularly in the four militancy-hit districts of south Kashmir—Kulgam, Anantnag, Shopian and Pulwama.

Earlier in Kulgam, where security forces killed four Hizbul militants as recently as in July this year, Omar held an impressive rally in the remote constituency of Damhal Hanjipora. Wearing a white flowing Kashmiri *dastar* (turban), he dispensed with the podium to address his audience